General Case Craft

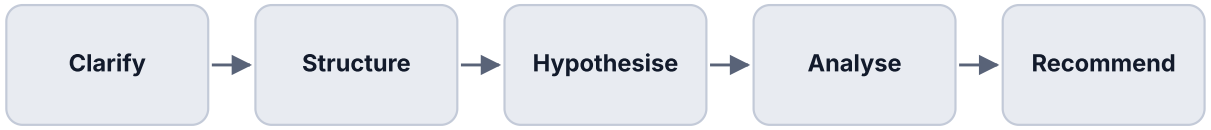
1. What a case interview really tests

A simulation of the job, scored on **structure, communication and composure** far more than the 'right' number. A candidate who structures beautifully and hedges the deep tech beats one who knows everything and rambles.

2. The five-step flow

1. **Clarify**: play the question back, ask 2 to 3 sharp questions (objective, success metric, timeframe, what's been tried)
2. **Structure out loud**: a MECE tree built for *this* problem
3. **Hypothesise**: a falsifiable best guess and the analysis that would test it
4. **Analyse with visible maths**: state assumptions, round hard, narrate
5. **Recommend answer-first**: recommendation, reasons, risks, next step

✎ DIAGRAM



Use the flow as a container you think inside.

3. Estimation

- **Top-down**: start from a big known number (population, households) and narrow with ratios
- **Bottom-up**: build from units (sales per store × number of stores)
- State every assumption, segment where ratios differ, round aggressively, finish with a **sanity check** per person or per unit
- Anchors: world ~8B · large country 30 to 70M · ~2.5 people per household · ~4 characters per token

4. Core frameworks (adapt, never recite)

- **Profitability**: Profit = Revenue − Cost; Revenue = volume × price; Cost = fixed + variable. If revenue is flat, look at cost and mix
- **Market entry**: is it attractive? can we win? do the economics work? how do we enter (build, buy, partner)? End with go / no-go and the conditions

- Lenses: **3Cs**, **4Ps**, **Porter's Five Forces**, **value chain**

> ⚠ A structure built for the problem beats a memorised framework forced onto it.

✎ DIAGRAM



The profitability tree unlocks a huge share of business cases.

5. Mental maths that survives pressure

- **Strip the zeros**, multiply the small numbers, put the zeros back
- **Split awkward numbers**: × 18 = × 10 + × 8; × 250 = × 1,000 ÷ 4; × 1.5 = the number plus half of it
- Percentages from **10%**: 15% = 10% + half of it; 35% = 3 × 10% + half of 10%
- Count zeros out loud, and check you finished the question (annual? multiply by 12)
- Months: half a year = 6, a third = 4, a quarter = 3

✎ DIAGRAM

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400,000 × 18
→ 4 × 18 = 4×10 + 4×8 = 40 + 32 = 72
→ put back 5 zeros
= 7,200,000
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The zero trick, worked.

6. Behavioural and fit (STAR)

- **Situation · Task · Action** (most of the time, say 'I') · **Result** (with a number)
- Prepare 5 to 6 stories, each mapped to 2 to 3 likely questions, rehearsed to ~90 seconds

- Pick stories that position you: a right-sizing decision, a measured quality climb, an adoption save, bad news delivered early with options

SAY IT

"Let me take 30 seconds to structure this." Then give 3 or 4 branches and say why each matters.